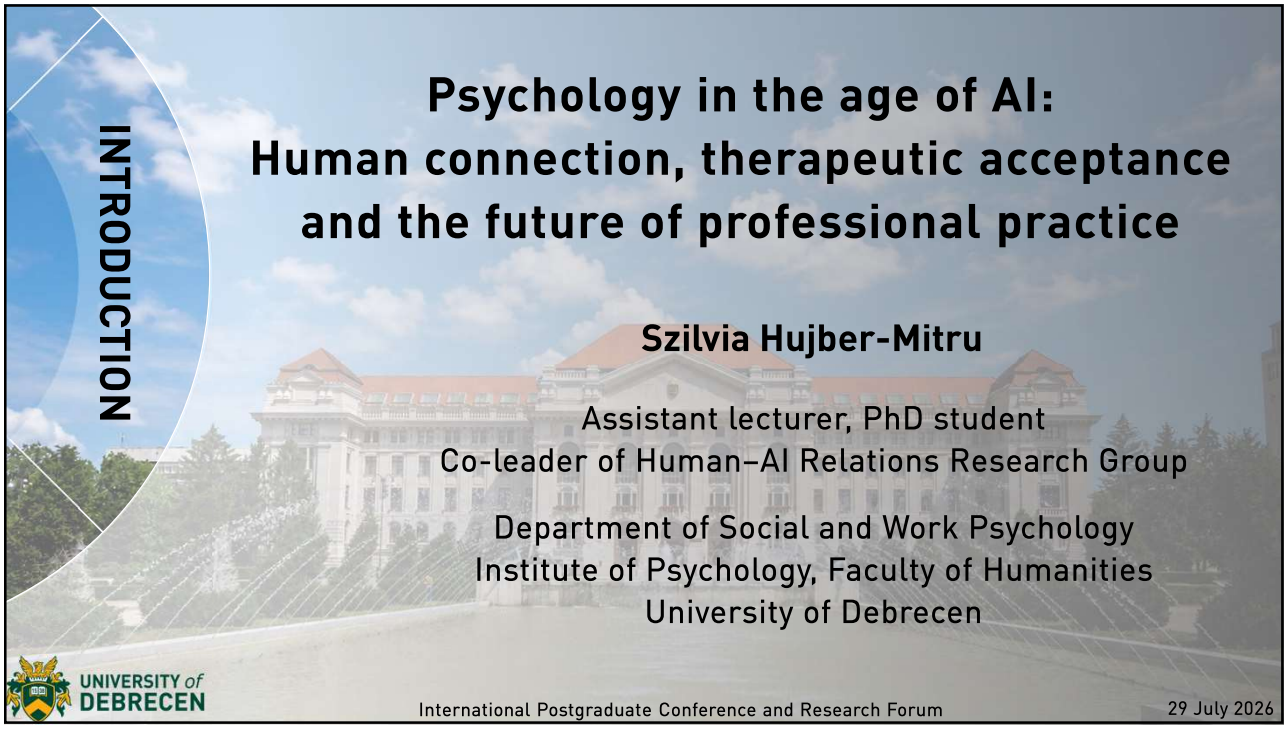

INTRODUCTION
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INTRODUCTION
Psychology in the age of AI:
Human connection, therapeutic acceptance and the future of professional practice
Szilvia Hujber-Mitru
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Department of Social and Work Psychology
Institute of Psychology, Faculty of Humanities
University of Debrecen
UNIVERSITY of DEBRECEN
International Postgraduate Conference and Research Forum
29 July 2026

BACKGROUND

Human-AI connection

- Human traits attributed to AI – anthropomorphism
  Araujo (2018); Epley et al. (2007)
- Human-AI relationships – trust and self-disclosure foster parasocial attachment to AI chatbots
  Skjuve et al. (2021); Youn & Jin (2021)
- Anthropomorphism and perceived social presence strengthen emotional attachment to AI agents
  Zhang & Rau (2023)
- Emotional attachment as a key factor in continued AI use
  Zhang & Yu (2025)
- Dependence on AI companions – risk of problematic use and psychological harm
  Laestadius et al. (2022); Xie et al. (2023)

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BACKGROUND

AI in psychotherapy and practice

- Clinical potential – Evidence of symptom reduction with AI-based conversational agents
  Fitzpatrick et al. (2017); Fulmer et al. (2018)
- AI acceptance shaped by perceived usefulness, ease of use, knowledge and attitudes
  Gado et al. (2022)
- Human or AI? – Source information changes response evaluation – trust, authenticity, preferences
  Jain et al. (2024); Ovsyannikova et al (2025)
- Ethical concerns – Privacy, autonomy, accountability, safety, loss of human contact
  Selenko et al. (2022); Strich et al. (2021)
- Supporting, transforming or replacing professionals? – Threats to professional identity
  Fiske et al. (2019); Rahsepar Meadi et al. (2025)

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BACKGROUND

Overview of the studies

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Hujber-Mitru & Lengyel (2026a)

Study 2 – Acceptance of GenAI in psychotherapy

Hujber-Mitru & Havan (2026)

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Hujber-Mitru & Lengyel (2026b)

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BACKGROUND

Studies methods

- Design: cross-sectional online survey (Google Forms)
- Sampling: convenience and snowball with targeted online recruitment
- Eligibility: Hungarian participants aged 14-80
- Participation: voluntary, anonymous
- Ethical approval: UD-IP-2025/69, UD-IP-2025/70, UD-IP-2025/135
- Analysis conducted in jamovi 2.7.24

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FINDINGS

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Hypothesis

- H1: Association between Social settings and Parasocial attachment to AI
- H2: Associations between Anthropomorphism, Attitudes towards AI and Parasocial attachment to AI
- H3: Associations between Anthropomorphism, Parasocial attachment to AI and AI use behavior
- H4: Association between Anthropomorphism, Parasocial attachment to AI and Problematic AI use

FINDINGS

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

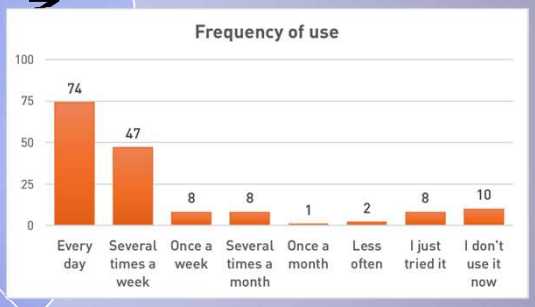
Sample

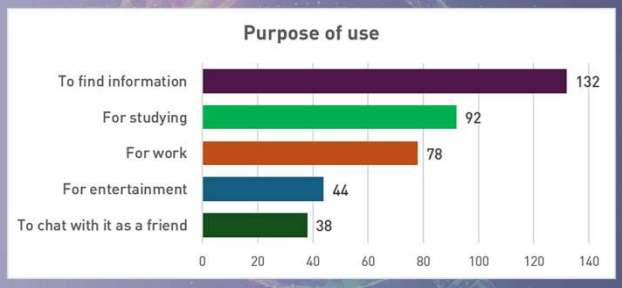
- Total sample: N = 158
- Hungarian participants aged 14-80
- Age: M = 34.6, SD = 13.0 Md = 31.5, range = 14-65 years
- Gender: 64% women (n=101); 35% men (n=55), 1% other (n=2)
- Education: 6% primary, 43% secondary, 51% tertiary
- Place of residence: 18% villages, 60% cities, 22% capital city
- Relationship status: 34% single, 30% in relationship, 30% married, 4% divorced, 2% prefer not to answer

FIN

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Sample

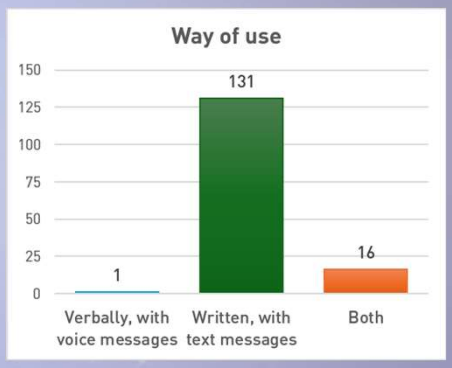


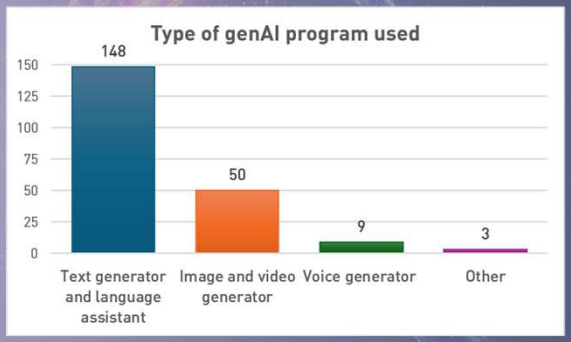


FINDINGS

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Sample

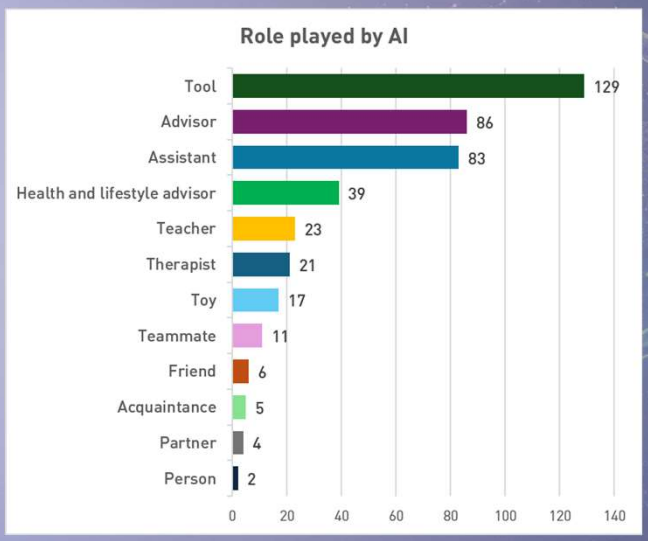




FINDINGS

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Sample



FINDINGS

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Measures

- Godspeed Questionnaire Series – Anthropomorphism — Bartneck et al. (2009)
- General Attitudes towards AI Scale — Schepman & Rodway (2020)
- Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology 2 — Bilos & Budimir (2024)
- Who To Turn To Scale (Parasocial attachment to AI) — Yang & Oshio (2025)
- Bergen Addiction Scale modified – AI version — Andreassen et al. (2012)
- De Jong Gierveld Loneliness Scale — De Jong Gierveld & Kamphuis (1985)
- Brief Fear of Negative Evaluation Scale — Rodebaugh et al (2004)
- Multidimensional Scale of Perceived Social Support — Zimet et al. (1988)
- WHO5 Well-Being Index — Bech (1996)

FIND

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Measures

Scale	Subscale	M	Md	SD	Normality	Cronbach-α
Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology 2	Performance expectancy	4.93	5.50	1.70	0.91***	0.91
	Effort expectancy	5.78	6.00	1.25	0.86***	0.92
	Social influence	3.17	3.00	1.71	0,93***	0.94
	Facilitating conditions	5.36	5.50	1.29	0,94***	0.75
	Hedonic motivation	4.28	4.33	1.86	0.96**	0.96
	Price value	3.77	4.00	1.67	0.94***	0.95
	Personal innovativeness	3.70	3.67	1.96	0.92***	0.91
	Habit	3.56	3.63	1.77	0.94***	0.88
	Behavioral intention	4.41	4.67	1.85	0,94***	0.90
	Use behavior	4.33	4.75	1.76	0.94***	0.88

Note: *p<0,05 **p<0,01 ***p<0,001

Scale	Subscale	M	Md	SD	Normality	Cronbach-α
Godspeed Questionnaire Series	Anthropomorphism	2.28	2.13	0.97	0.94***	0.82
General Attitudes towards Artificial Intelligence Scale	Positive attitude	3.24	3.38	0.96	0.96**	0.92
	Negative attitude	3.20	3.38	0.82	0.97**	0.81
Who To Turn To Scale		19.30	0.00	27.62	0.72***	0.83
Bergen Addiction Scale – AI version		8.67	7.50	3.39	0.78***	0.75
De Jong Gierveld Loneliness Scale		17.61	16.00	5.95	0.89***	0.90
Brief Fear of Negative Evaluation Scale		2.54	2.19	1.25	0.91***	0.96
Multidimensional Scale of Perceived Social Support	Family support	3.75	4.25	1.29	0.60***	0.94
	Friends support	4.07	4.67	1.15	0.86***	0.95
	Significant others support	4.56	5.00	0.84	0.79***	0.92
WHO5 Well-Being Index		33.01	36.00	13.66	0.98**	0.84

Note: *p<0,05 **p<0,01 ***p<0,001

FINDINGS

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Results

- H1a: Social settings and Parasocial attachment to AI – Correlation

Loneliness and Parasocial attachment to AI:

Spearman ρ = .26, p < .001

Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology 2 – Social influence and Parasocial attachment to AI:

Spearman ρ = .37, p < .001

Perceived social support and Parasocial attachment to AI:

From family: **Spearman ρ = -.18, p = .027**

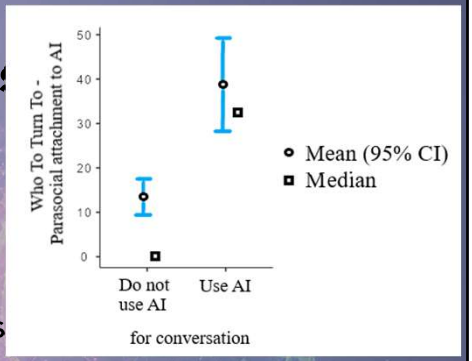
From friends: **Spearman ρ = -.21, p = .007**

FINDINGS

Study 1 – GenAI as a conver

Results

- H1b: Social settings and Parasocial comparison



Considers AI a friend for conversations

Mann-Whitney U = 1048.5, p < .001, r = 0.523

Difference in Parasocial attachment	n	M	Md	SD
Use AI for conversation	36	38.89	33.33	5.27
Does not use AI for conversation	122	13.53	0.00	2.13

FINDINGS

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Results

- H2: Connections between Anthropomorphism, Attitudes towards AI and Parasocial attachment to AI – Correlation

Measure	1	2	3
1. Godspeed Anthropomorphism	–		
2. General Attitudes towards AI – Positive attitude	.36***	–	
3. Who To Turn To Scale (Parasocial attachment to AI)	.47***	.37***	–

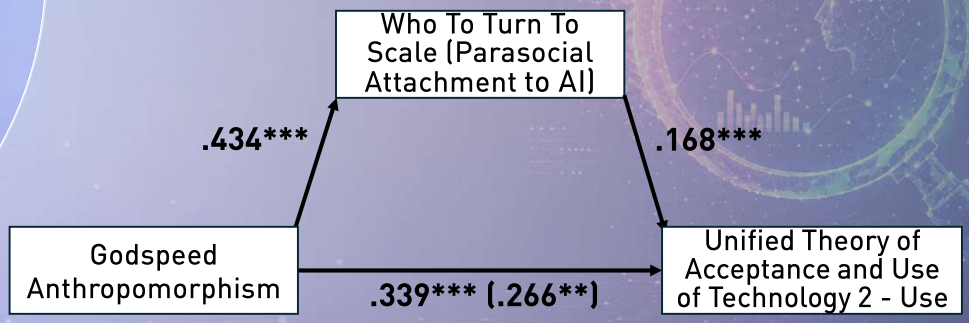
Note: *p<0.05 **p<0.01 ***p<0.001

FINDINGS

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Results

- H3a: Connections between Anthropomorphism, Parasocial attachment to AI and AI use behavior – Mediation

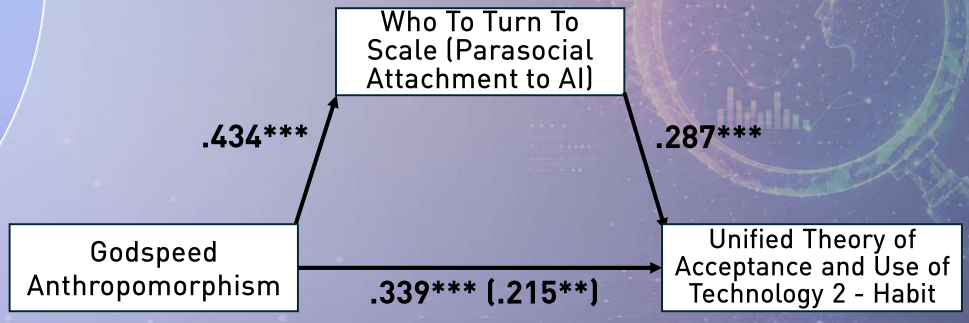


FINDINGS

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Results

- H3b: Connections between Anthropomorphism, Parasocial attachment to AI and habitual AI use – Mediation



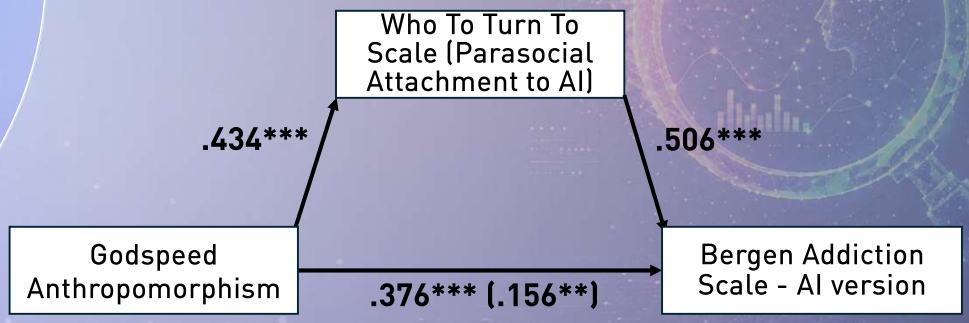
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FINDINGS

Study 1 – GenAI as a conversational partner

Results

- H4: Connections between Anthropomorphism, Parasocial attachment to AI and Problematic AI use – Mediation



FINDINGS

Study 2 – Acceptance of GenAI in psychotherapy

Hypothesis

- H1: Association between AI knowledge, Attitudes towards Technology and Acceptance of AI-based psychotherapy
- H2: Differences in Acceptance of AI-based psychotherapy
- H3: Differences in Concerns and risks regarding the use of AI in therapy and Importance of human therapeutic alliance
- H4: Importance of Perceived usefulness of AI in therapy, Willingness to use AI in therapy and Importance of human therapeutic alliance
- H5: Gender differences in Self-Stigma of Seeking Help and Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy

FINDINGS

Study 2 – Acceptance of GenAI in psychotherapy

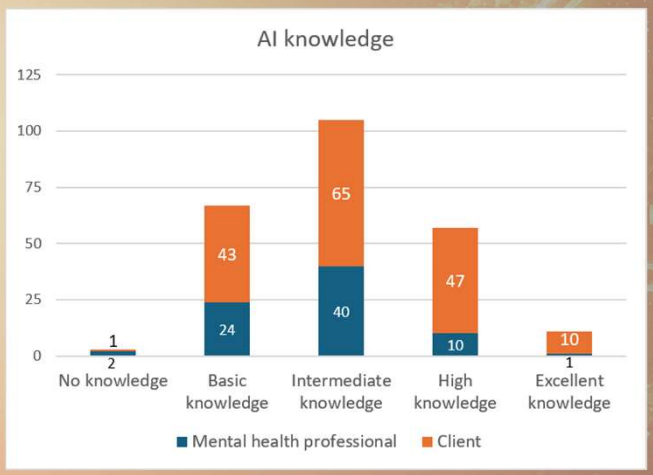
Sample

- Total sample: N = 244
- Hungarian participants aged 18-80
- Groups: Mental health professionals n = 77; Clients n = 167
- Age: M = 41.1, SD = 10.2 Md = 41, range = 18-73 years
- Gender: 62% women (n=152); 37% men (n=91), 1% other (n=1)
- Place of residence: 15% villages, 59% cities, 26% capital city
- Relationship status: 13% single, 15% in relationship, 66% married, 4% divorced, 2% widow

FINDINGS

Study 2 – Acceptance of GenAI in psychotherapy

Sample



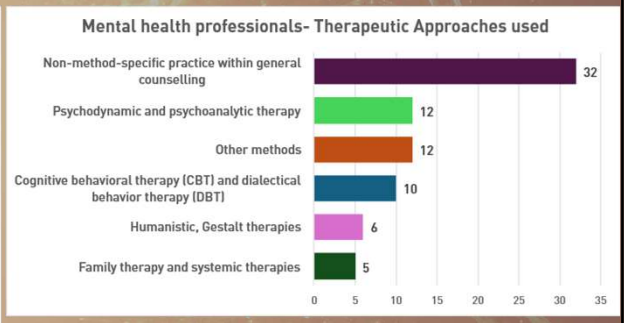
International Postgraduate Conference and Research Forum

FINDINGS

Study 2 – Acceptance of GenAI in psychotherapy

Sample





FINDINGS

Study 2 – Acceptance of GenAI in psychotherapy

Measures

- Self-Stigma of Seeking Help Scale (clients only) — Vogel et al. (2006)
- Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy Scale — Aktan et al. (2022)
- Technology Adoption Propensity Index — Ratchford & Barnhart (2012)
- UTAUT-based questionnaire – own items — Venkatesh et al (2003)
  - Perceived usefulness of AI in therapy
  - Willingness to use AI in therapy
  - Concerns and risks regarding the use of AI in therapy
  - Importance of human therapeutic alliance
- Professional background and therapeutic orientation
- AI knowledge and previous AI experiences

FINDINGS

Study 2 – Acce…therapy

Measures

Full sample

Scale	N	M	Md	SD	Normality	Cronbach-α
Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy Scale	244	2.45	2.50	0.67	0.98***	0.70
Technology Adoption Propensity Index	244	4.09	4.00	0.67	0.98***	0.67
Self-Stigma of Seeking Help Scale	244					
Perceived usefulness of AI in therapy	244	3.13	3.25	0.93	0.98***	0.81
Willingness to use AI in therapy	244	3.30	3.33	0.99	0.97***	0.73
Concerns and risks regarding the use of AI in therapy	244	3.54	3.50	0.94	0.96***	0.70
Importance of human therapeutic alliance	244	3.69	3.75	0.80	0.97***	0.63

Note: *p<0,05 **p<0,01 ***p<0,001

Mental health professionals

Scale	N	M	Md	SD	Normality	Cronbach-α
Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy Scale	77	2.25	2.33	0.55	0.97*	0.58
Technology Adoption Propensity Index	77	3.95	3.93	0.59	0.99	0.68
Self-Stigma of Seeking Help Scale	77					
Perceived usefulness of AI in therapy	77	3.12	3.25	0.92	0.97*	0.80
Willingness to use AI in therapy	77	3.02	3.00	0.95	0.98	0.75
Concerns and risks regarding the use of AI in therapy	77	3.81	3.75	0.79	0.96**	0.63
Importance of human therapeutic alliance	77	3.87	4.00	0.68	0.97**	0.56

Note: *p<0,05 **p<0,01 ***p<0,001

Clients

Scale	N	M	Md	SD	Normality	Cronbach-α
Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy Scale	167	2.55	2.50	0.70	0.99*	0.72
Technology Adoption Propensity Index	167	4.15	4.07	0.70	0,98**	0.71
Self-Stigma of Seeking Help Scale	167	1.96	1.90	0.61	0.94***	0.72
Perceived usefulness of AI in therapy	167	3.13	3.25	0.94	0.97**	0.82
Willingness to use AI in therapy	167	3.43	3.33	0.98	0.97***	0.74
Concerns and risks regarding the use of AI in therapy	167	3.41	3.50	0,97	0.97***	0.73
Importance of human therapeutic alliance	167	3.61	3.75	0,83	0.97***	0.65

Note: *p<0,05 **p<0,01 ***p<0,001

FINDINGS

Study 2 – Acceptance of GenAI in psychotherapy

Results

- H1: Association between AI knowledge, Attitudes towards Technology and Acceptance of AI-based psychotherapy – Correlation

Measure (N = 244)	1	2	3	4
1. AI knowledge	–			
2. Perceived usefulness	.21***	–		
3. Technology Adoption Propensity	.54***	.26***	–	
4. Acceptance of AI-based psychotherapy	.05	.56***	.20**	–

Note: *p<0.05 **p<0.01 ***p<0.001

FINDINGS

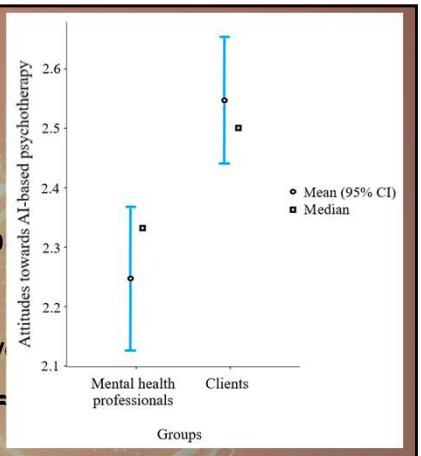
Study 2 – Acceptance of GenAI

Results

- H2: Differences in Acceptance of AI-b
  Group comparison

Differences in Acceptance of AI-Based Psy

Mann-Whitney U = 4798.0, p < .001, r =



Difference in Acceptance of AI-based psychotherapy	n	M	Md	SD
Mental health professionals	77	2.25	2.33	0.55
Clients	167	2.55	2.50	0.70

FINDINGS

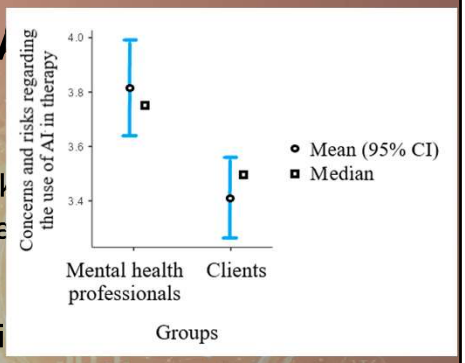
Study 2 – Acceptance of GenA

Results

- H3a: Differences in Concerns and risk
  in therapy and Importance of huma
  Group comparison

Differences in Concerns and risks regardi

Mann-Whitney U = 4832.5, p = .001, r = 0.248



Differences in Concerns and risks	n	M	Md	SD
Mental health professionals	77	3.81	3.75	0.79
Clients	167	3.50	3.50	0.97

FINDINGS

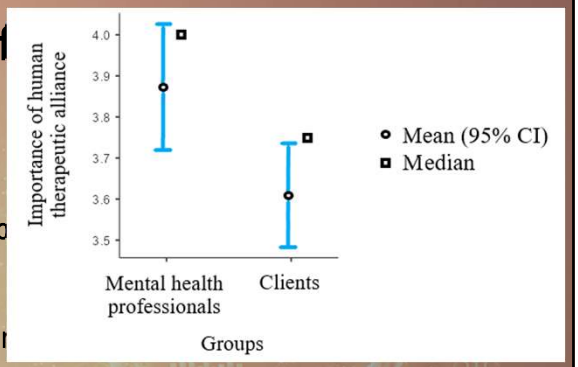
Study 2 – Acceptance of

Results

- H3b: Differences in Concerns
  in therapy and Importance o
  Group comparison

Differences in Importance of hu

Mann-Whitney U = 5338.5, p = .032, r = 0.170



Difference in Human therapeutic alliance	n	M	Md	SD
Mental health professionals	77	3.87	4.00	0.68
Clients	167	3.61	3.75	0.83

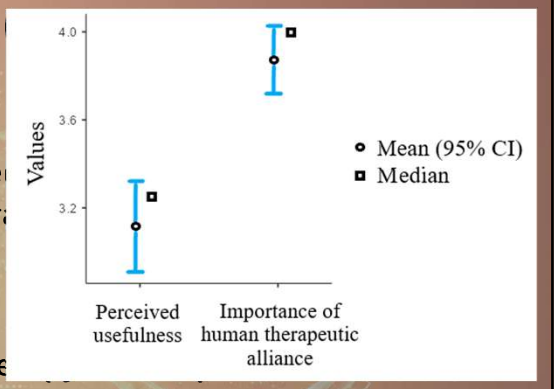
FINDINGS

Study 2 – Acceptance of

Results

- H4a: Importance of Perceive
  Willingness to use AI in ther
  therapeutic alliance – Paired
  professionals

Perceived usefulness of AI in the
therapeutic alliance: **Wilcoxon W = 463.5, p < .001, r = 0.627**



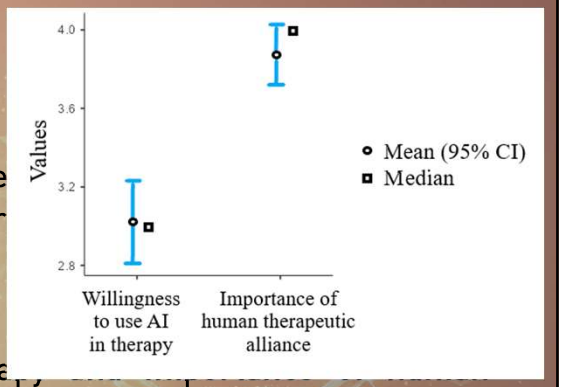
Measure	n	M	Md	SD
Perceived usefulness of AI in therapy	77	3.12	3.25	0.92
Importance of human therapeutic alliance	77	3.87	4.00	0.68

FINDINGS

Study 2 – Acceptance of

Results

- H4b: Importance of Perceive
  Willingness to use AI in ther
  therapeutic alliance – Paired
  professionals



Willingness to use AI in thera
therapeutic alliance: **Wilcoxon W = 431, p < .001, r = 0.700**

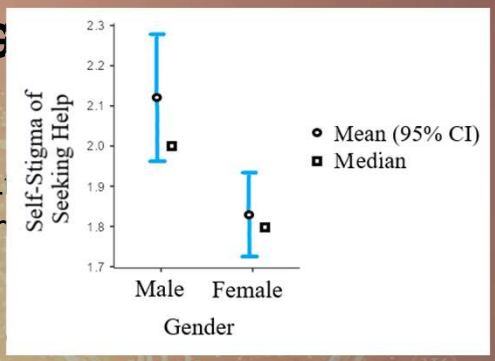
Measure	n	M	Md	SD
Willingness to use AI in therapy	77	3.02	3.00	0.95
Importance of human therapeutic alliance	77	3.87	4.00	0.68

FINDINGS

Study 2 – Acceptance of G

Results

- H5a: Gender differences in Sel
  Attitude Towards AI-based Psych
  among *Clients*



Gender differences in Self-Stigma
Mann-Whitney U = 2558.0, p = .006, r = 0.246

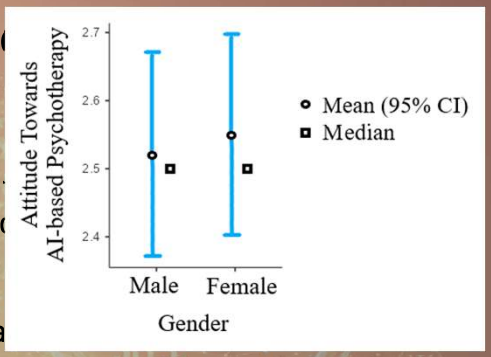
Gender differences in Self-Stigma of Seeking Help	n	M	Md	SD
Male	73	2.12	2.00	0.69
Female	93	1.83	1.80	0.52

FINDINGS

Study 2 – Acceptance of G

Results

- H5b: Gender differences in Self- Attitude Towards AI-based Psycho among *Clients*



Gender differences in Attitude Towa

Mann-Whitney U = 3379.5, p = .962

Gender differences in Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy:	n	M	Md	SD
Male	73	2.52	2.50	0.65
Female	93	2.55	2.50	0.72

FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Hypothesis

- H1: Differences in Attitudes towards AI
- H2: Differences in Perceived Professional Threat
- H3: Association between AI Self-Reflective Use, Attitude towards AI and Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy
- H4: Association between Professional Identity–Career Commitment, Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy and Perceived Professional Threat
- H5: Exploratory regression model of Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy

FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

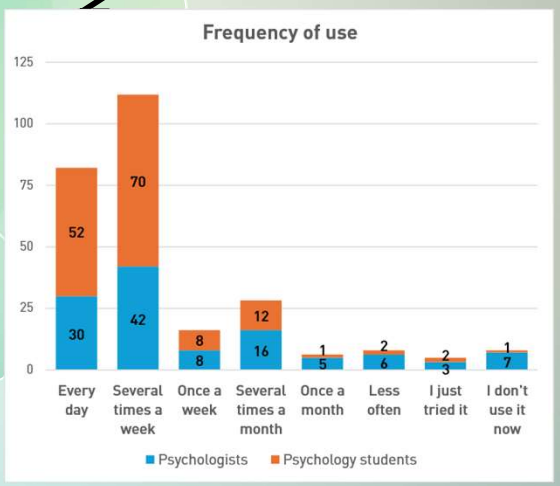
Sample

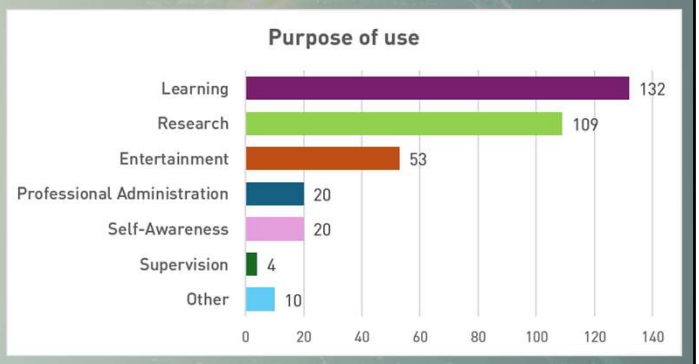
- Total sample: N = 265
- Hungarian participants aged 18-80
- Groups: Psychologists n = 117; Psychology students n = 148
- Age – Psychologists: M = 36.0, SD = 8.9 Md = 34, range = 22-71 years
- Age – Psychology students: M = 27.9, SD = 9.6 Md = 23, range = 19-54 years
- Gender: 80% women (n=213); 19% men (n=50), 1% other (n=2)
- Relationship status: 23% single, 42% in relationship, 33% married, 2% divorced

FIN

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Sample



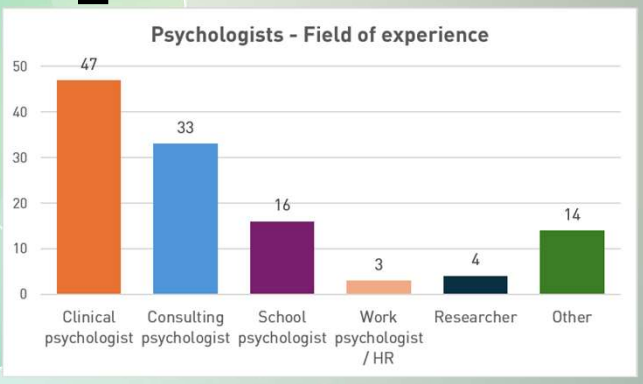


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FIN

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Sample





FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Measures

- General Attitudes towards Artificial Intelligence Scale — Schepman & Rodway (2020)
- Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy Scale — Aktan et al. (2022)
- Professional Identity and Career Commitment — Carson & Bedeian (1994)
- Perceived Professional Threat Scale – own items
- AI Self-Reflective Use Scale – own items
- Purpose and frequency of AI use

FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Measures

Full sample

Scale	Subscale	N	M	Md	SD	Normality	Cronbach-α
General Attitudes towards Artificial Intelligence Scale	Positive attitude	265	3.34	3.42	0.69	0.99**	0.85
	Negative attitude	265	2.83	2.88	0.76	0.98***	0.81
Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy Scale		265	2.01	2.00	0.62	0.96***	0.71
Professional Identity and Career Commitment		265	3.55	3.75	0.51	0.82***	0.83
Perceived Professional Threat Scale		265	2.30	2.10	0.95	0.93***	0.92
AI Self-Reflective Use Scale		265	2.05	1.50	1.20	0.82***	0.95

Note: *p<0,05 **p<0,01 ***p<0,001

Psychologists

Scale	Subscale	N	M	Md	SD	Normality	Cronbach-α
General Attitudes towards Artificial Intelligence Scale	Positive attitude	117	3.37	3.42	0.75	0.96**	0.88
	Negative attitude	117	3.28	3.38	0.75	0.97**	0.80
Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy Scale		117	2.13	2.17	0.67	0.97*	0.73
Professional Identity and Career Commitment		117	3.54	3.63	0.47	0.85***	0.79
Perceived Professional Threat Scale		117	2.04	2.00	0.80	0.91***	0.89
AI Self-Reflective Use Scale		117	1.90	1.30	1.13	0.78***	0.95

Note: *p<0,05 **p<0,01 ***p<0,001

Psychology students

Scale	Subscale	N	M	Md	SD	Normality	Cronbach-α
General Attitudes towards Artificial Intelligence Scale	Positive attitude	148	3.31	3.33	0.64	0.99	0.83
	Negative attitude	148	3.07	3.06	0.76	0.98*	0.82
Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy Scale		148	1.92	1.83	0.56	0.93***	0.67
Professional Identity and Career Commitment		148	3.55	3.75	0.54	0.79***	0.86
Perceived Professional Threat Scale		148	2.50	2.30	1.02	0.95***	0.93
AI Self-Reflective Use Scale		148	2.16	1.70	1.24	0.85***	0.95

Note: *p<0,05 **p<0,01 ***p<0,001

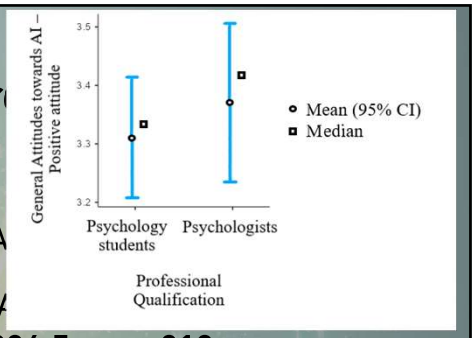
FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or thr

Results

- H1a: Differences in Attitudes towards A

Differences in Attitudes towards A
Qualifications: **Mann-Whitney U = 7896.5, p = .219**



Differences in General Attitudes towards AI – Positive attitude	n	M	Md	SD
Psychologists	117	3.37	3.34	0.75
Psychology students	148	3.31	3.33	0.64

FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Results

- H1a: Differences in Attitudes towards AI – Group comparison

Differences in Attitudes towards AI based on Professional Qualifications:

ANCOVA - Age as covariate

Age: $F(1, 262) = 5{,}10$; $p = 0.025$, $n^2_p = .020$

Professional qualification: $F(1,262) = 0.06$, $p = .806$, $n^2_p < .001$

FINDINGS

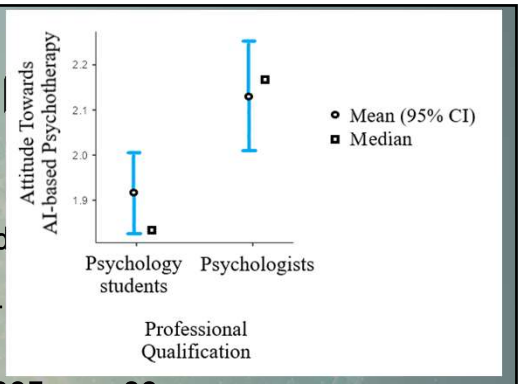
Study 3 – Opportunity or t

Results

- H1b: Differences in Attitudes toward

Differences in Attitude Towards AI-
Professional Qualifications:

Mann-Whitney U = 6930.5, p = .005, r = .20



Differences in Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy	n	M	Md	SD
Psychologists	117	2.13	2.17	0.67
Psychology students	148	1.92	1.83	0.56

FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Results

- H1b: Differences in Attitudes towards AI – Group comparison

Differences in Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy based on Professional Qualifications:

ANCOVA - Age as covariate

Age: $F(1, 262) = 3.15$; $p = 0.077$, $n^2_p = .010$

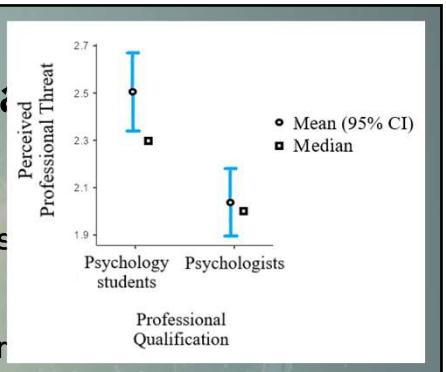
Professional qualification: $F(1,262) = 3.64$, $p = .050$, $n^2_p = .014$

FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threa

Results

- H2a: Differences in Perceived Profes comparison



Differences in Perceived Professional Thr
Qualifications: **Mann-Whitney U = 6378, p < .001, r = .26**

Differences in Perceived Professional Threat	n	M	Md	SD
Psychologists	117	2.04	2.00	0.80
Psychology students	148	2.51	2.30	1.01

FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Results

- H2a: Differences in Perceived Professional Threat – Group comparison

Differences in Perceived Professional Threat based on Professional Qualifications:

ANCOVA - Age as covariate

Age: $F(1, 262) = 0.35$; $p = 0.553$, $n^2_p = .001$

Professional qualification: $F(1,262) = 12.15$, $p < .001$, $n^2_p = .044$

FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Results

- H3: Connection between AI Self-Reflective Use, Attitude towards AI and Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy – Correlation

Measure (N = 265)	1	2	3
1. AI Self-Reflective Use	–		
2. General attitude towards AI – Positive attitude	.35***	–	
3. Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy	.27***	.46***	–

Note: *p<0.05 **p<0.01 ***p<0.001

FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Results

- H4: Connection between Professional Identity - Career Commitment, Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy and Perceived Professional Threat – Correlation

Professional Identity - Career Commitment and Perceived Professional Threat: **Spearman ρ = -.22, p < .001**

Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy and Perceived Professional Threat: **Spearman ρ = .21, p < .001**

FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Results

- H5: Exploratory regression model of Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy – Multiple linear regression

$R = .595$, $R^2 = .354$, $R^2_{adj} = .345$ **$F(4,260) = 35.82$, $p < .001$**

DW = 1.93, p = .532

VIF = 1.01–1.11

Tolerance = .904–.993

FINDINGS

Study 3 – Opportunity or threat to psychology?

Results

- H5: Exploratory regression model of Attitude Towards AI-based Psychotherapy – Multiple linear regression

$R = .595$, $R^2 = .354$, $R^2_{adj} = .345$ $F(3,261) = 47.72$, $p < .001$

Predictor	*B*	SE	t	p
Intercept	-.013	.174	-0.08	.938
Positive Attitude toward AI	.438	.045	9.85	< .001
Perceived Professional Threat	.191	.033	5.76	< .001
Professional Qualifications: Psychologists and Students	.277	.064	4.35	< .001

DISCUSSION

Conclusions and Implications

- **Human-like AI can be a psychologically meaningful interaction partner and a bond can develop**
  Skjuve et al. (2021); Zhang & Rau (2023)
- **Attachment-based mechanisms behind habitual and problematic AI use**
  Laestadius et al. (2024); Zhang & Yu (2025)
- **AI-based psychotherapy: higher openness among potential clients**
  Aktan et al. (2022); Cecil et al. (2025)
- **Therapeutic potential and professional threat can coexist**
  Selenko et al. (2022); Wagner & Schwind (2025)
- **Professional concerns around risk and therapeutic alliance**
  Benda et al. (2024); Cross et al. (2024); Strich et al. (2021)
- **AI as support, not replacement**
  Kleine et al. (2023); Wagner & Schwind (2025)
- **Need for AI-specific training and professional guidelines**
  Cecil et al. (2025); Goldie et al. (2025)

DISCUSSION

Limitations

- Cross-sectional, correlational designs
- Convenience-based online sampling
- Non-representative Hungarian samples
- Self-report and selection bias
- Unequal subgroup sizes
- Limited validation of adapted and self-developed scales
- Rapidly evolving AI context

DISCUSSION

Future Research

- Cross-cultural replication
- Longitudinal pathways from attachment to problematic use
- Human, AI-assisted, and AI-only support models
- Clinical and help-seeking populations
- Validation of AI-specific psychological measures
- AI literacy and professional training interventions
- From understanding AI-related attitudes to designing safe, evidence-based human–AI collaboration

DISCUSSION

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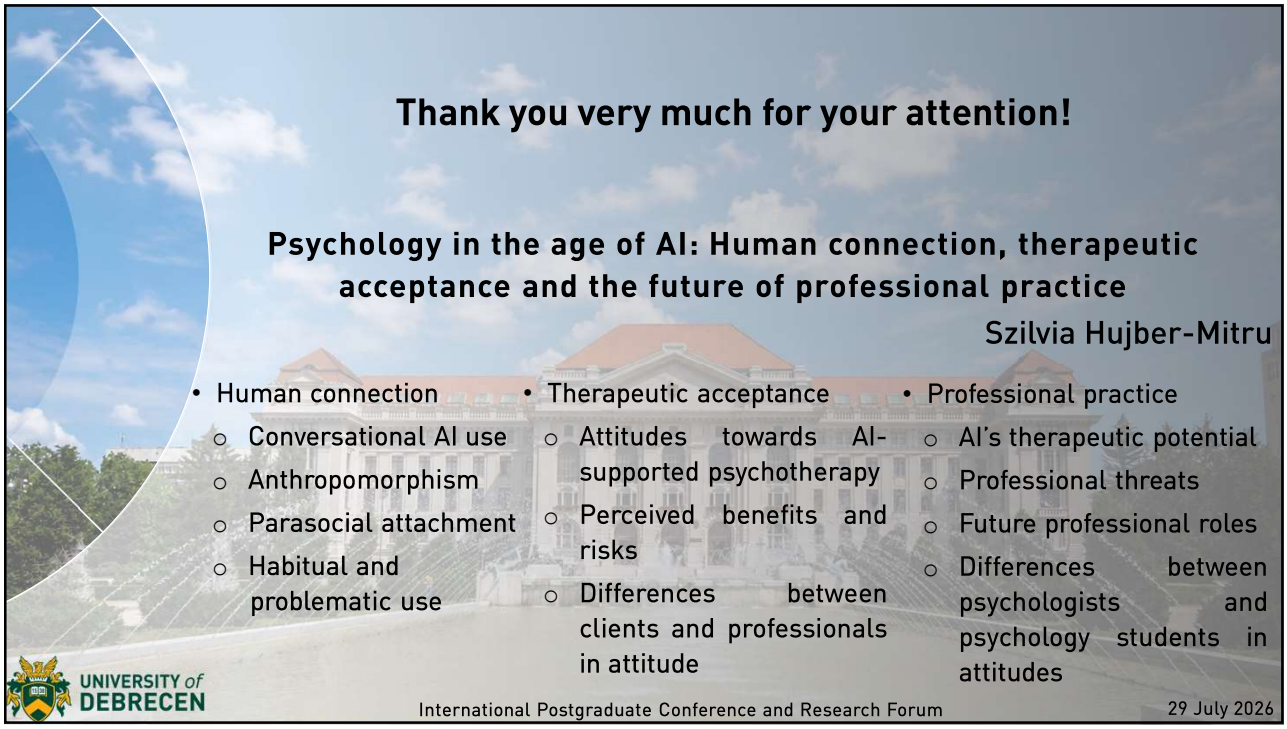
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Psychology in the age of AI: Human connection, therapeutic acceptance and the future of professional practice
Szilvia Hujber-Mitru
Human connection
Conversational AI use
Anthropomorphism
Parasocial attachment
Habitual and problematic use
Therapeutic acceptance
Attitudes towards AI-supported psychotherapy
Perceived benefits and risks
Differences between clients and professionals in attitude
Professional practice
AI's therapeutic potential
Professional threats
Future professional roles
Differences between psychologists and psychology students in attitudes
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